

# The 3-Step Quarter-Acre Starter Map

A free printable checklist showing exactly how to map sun exposure, choose your first 5 crops, and lay out your first growing season — before you buy a single seed packet.

## Why Most Backyard Gardens Never Get Past 'Hobby' Level

Most people plant a few tomato plants, get a modest harvest, and call it a garden. The self-sufficient backyards that actually replace grocery trips are designed differently from day one — stacked in layers, planned around succession planting, and built to produce through most of the year instead of one summer burst.

## The Quarter-Acre Reality

A well-planned quarter acre can support a rotating vegetable garden, a small flock of laying hens, a couple of dwarf fruit trees, and a compost system that feeds it all back — without violating most suburban zoning rules. The limiting factor usually isn't space, it's not knowing where to start.

## Small Mistakes That Quietly Kill Backyard Harvests

Overcrowded beds, poor sun mapping, skipping soil testing, and planting everything at once instead of staggering harvests are the most common reasons backyard growers give up after one season. Each one is fixable in an afternoon once you know to look for it.